

HIMACHAL PRADESH/ ELECTIONS

THAKUR VS THAKUR

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

On September 25, Himachal Pradesh chief minister Jairam Thakur took five shots at the target at the inauguration of a new shooting range in Kasauli's premium Pinegrove School. He missed all five. Amid the preparations for the forthcoming assembly election, the CM has been busy inaugurating a bevy of projects across the state. Thakur is leading the BJP campaign in the hill state and trying to hit a target no other chief minister has hit before—get a repeat mandate.

Himachal could go to the polls in the first half of November and, more than Thakur, BJP national president Jagat Prakash Nadda is invested in the results. It's his home state, and the election comes just two months before his tenure ends. The buzz is that Nadda may get an extension or even a second term as party chief and he can ill afford an adverse result. He flew in on October 2 to finalise the campaign details before the elections are announced (expected in the second week of October) and, crucially, talk to some of the candidates who could be dropped.

In a change from the BJP script in poll-bound states where chief ministers are routinely axed, Nadda is backing Thakur to the hilt. State BJP leaders believe the state's perceived pro-Hindutva slant and vote-catcher-in-chief Prime Minister Narendra Modi will help the party win a second consecutive term. On October 5, PM Modi was in Kullu for the famous Dussehra fair. It's the first time a prime minister is joining the celebrations and the BJP will be hoping it boosts the pro-Hindu sentiment in the state. Modi also inaugurated the new AIIMS in Bilaspur.

Thakur faces two big challenges—anti-incumbency against his government and many of his MLAs, and rampant factionalism in the state BJP. In addition, there are two more worries: the Congress is regrouping under Pratibha Singh, widow of six-time CM Virbhadra Singh, and the fact that Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has been unable to carry their Punjab momentum into Himachal. Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University, says AAP could have split the anti-incumbency vote, but the party is still picking up the pieces after Union minister Anurag Thakur arranged the defection of state unit chief Anoop Kesari. In the previous assembly polls, the BJP got 48.8 per cent of the vote, a jump of 10.3 per cent—the gains were not from swing voters but the collapse of smaller parties. The Congress got 41.7 per cent votes, a dip of just 1.1 per cent.

The state BJP also faces dissent within. Loyalists of ex-CM Prem Kumar Dhumal have relentlessly lobbied for his son Anurag Thakur to be chief minister, complaining that they have been continuously ignored in the past five years. They cite the example of former state unit chief Khimi Ram—an erstwhile Dhumal loyalist—who joined the Congress in July as he wasn't accommodated. The party has deployed BJP vice-president and state in-charge Saudan Singh to sort out the issues.

Meanwhile, the CM has to tackle everyday problems such as the lack of jobs for the youth, the apple growers' fury over GST and the "dumping" of imported variants, state employees who want the old pension scheme back...the

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